

An Actual Class Vs. A Virtual Classroom Session

I'm one of the lucky few to have had the opportunity to experience both a regular classroom session as well as a virtual one. So what's better, in terms of the learning experience, and more importantly, in terms of fun?

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Me trying to learn something in a typical class



No writing notes—everything's already scanned!

Stage 1

Guest lecturers are often invited to take sessions on special topics in colleges. Some of them are really interesting and keep you engrossed, while others can put you to sleep faster than a sledgehammer to the temple! The guest this time, was from the US, so we tried to show him some respect by passing fewer chits around.

A few months later, my college scheduled a virtual classroom session with a different professor from the US. We were worried that our shared 1 MBps connection might not suffice; however, it seemed good enough. The time difference was painful, because not only was the professor in the US, a lot of the students were from different countries / cities.

Stage 2

This lecturer's style appeared to be dictating from pre-prepared notes—70 pages of them! Our hands were killing us as we wrote page after page trying to keep pace with his dictation. Finally a friend hit upon a solution, and began pretending to not understand his American accent, making him repeat himself often. He got the drift and slowed down.

This professor had a thicker accent than the previous one, but because we were in a multinational virtual classroom, a lot of us were too shy to ask her to repeat herself. What she did do, before leaving, was to give the most confused-looking out of the lot her e-mail address.

Stage 3

The distinct advantage of the real classroom was the fact that I could ask questions and have them answered immediately. Also, with everyone present, the lecturer didn't need to explain the same thing over and over again to all 30 students!

The biggest advantage of the virtual world is the fact that all course material and suggested reading are already in the digital format. Photocopies fade, and aren't as clear.

Stage 4

Thankfully, he left us a copy of his notes so we could all make photocopies for ourselves. Good thing too, because writing 70 pages at a speed of a page a minute is just a tad much for me!

The professor kept in touch with us via e-mail, and even sent us her notes, pictures, audio, and other material after the session. The tech way was proving to be the couch potato's dream!

Fun: 4.5/10 (What did you expect?)



Fun: 7/10 (A novel experience!)



**AND
THE
WINNER
IS...**

The old way has the advantage of face-to-face interaction, and you get answers faster. It also means a smaller class with more attention being paid to each individual student. This was a tough choice, but I chose to go with the tech way as the winner. The virtual

session helped us interact not only with the professor, but also with people from across the globe. Besides, I'll do anything to have my notes in e-format! Of course, if there's no broadband connection, you'll just have to forget about the virtual classroom!